Alert Content

Title: Suspicious Office Outbound Connections

Time: 2024-01-05 14:04:23 UTC

Hostname: DESKTOP-AHG74N

User: Bobby

Process: C:\Program Files\Microsoft Office\Office16\WINWORD.EXE

Outbound Connection: 5.180.114.198:443

File Hash: 15ce7d3c879975ca81777cf58f47409283e34ec1fe8e966fde608bc7eda16646

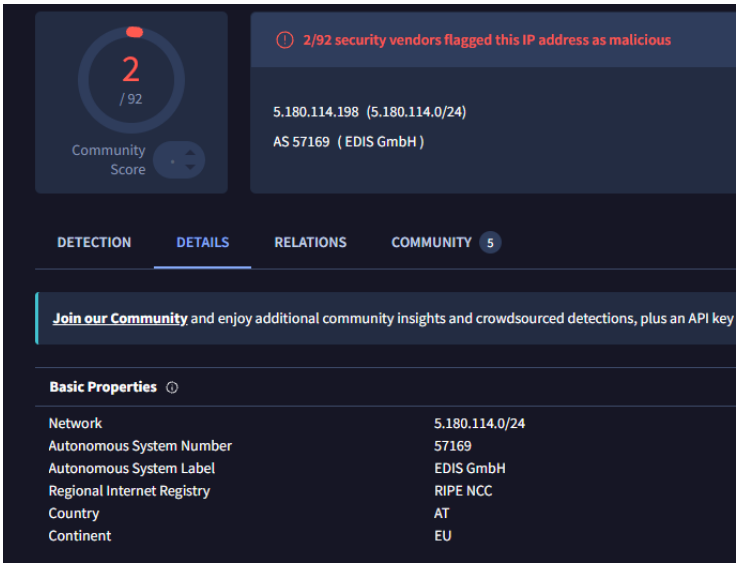
Investigation

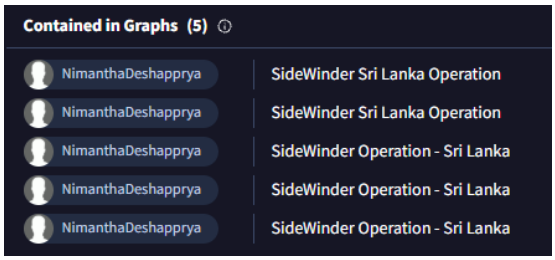
Summary:

On 2024-01-05 14:04:23 UTC, a Word document opened by Bobby was detected to have made an outbound connection to 5[.]180[.]114[.]198, an IP Address known to have been used in operations by the SideWinder threat group. The reputation of the file hash reports that it exploits CVE-2017-0199, communicating with the malicious domains direct888[.]net and navy-lk.direct888[.]net in previous phishing attacks by SideWinder.

IOC IP: 5[.]180[.]114[.]198

VirusTotal reports that only 2 security vendors flagged this IP address as malicious and that it has appeared in previous operations of the threat group, Sidewinder. The IP is affiliated with EDIS GmbH in Austria.

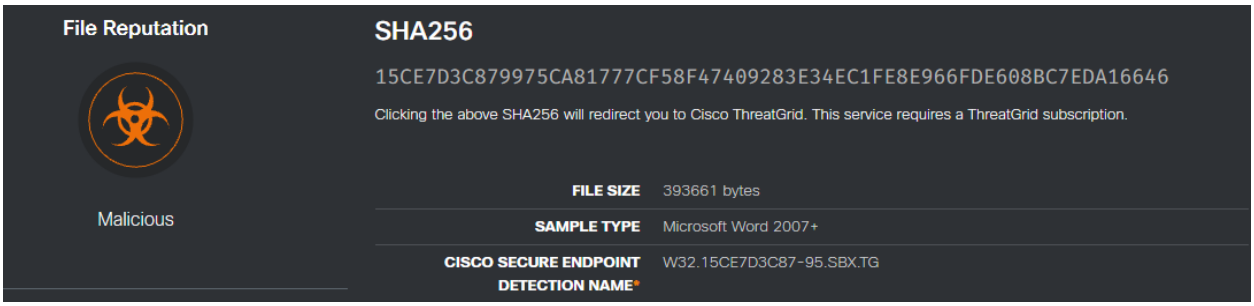


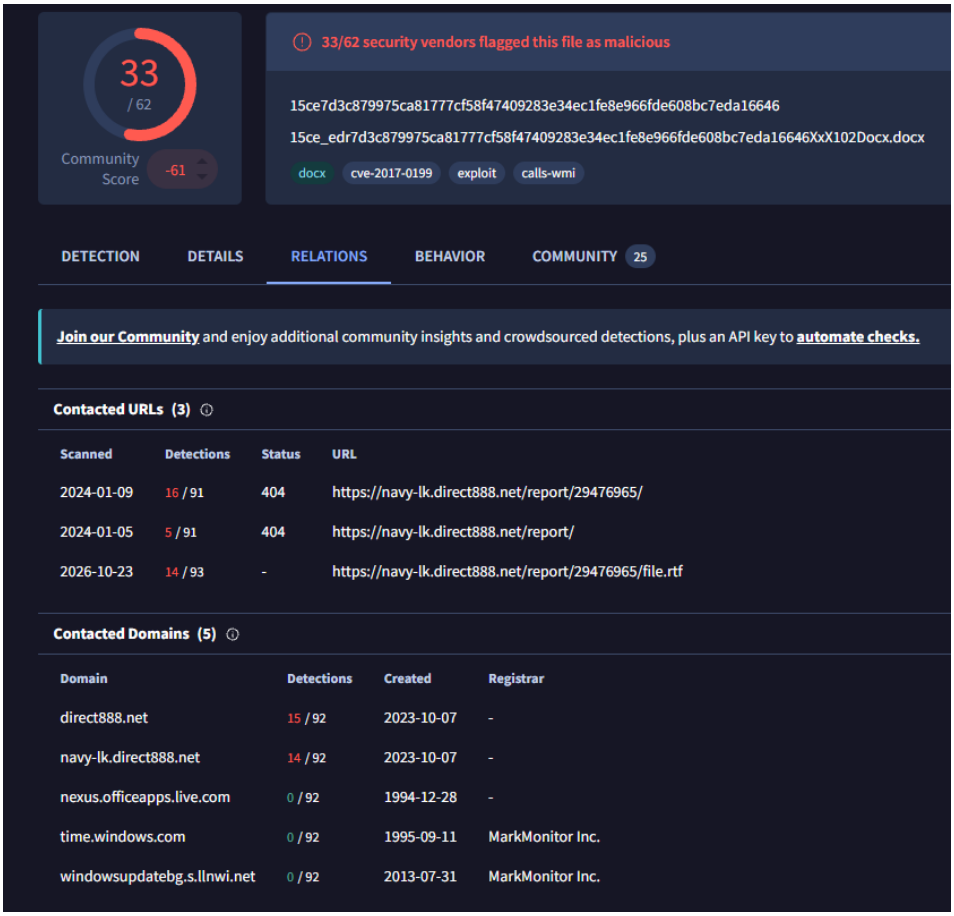


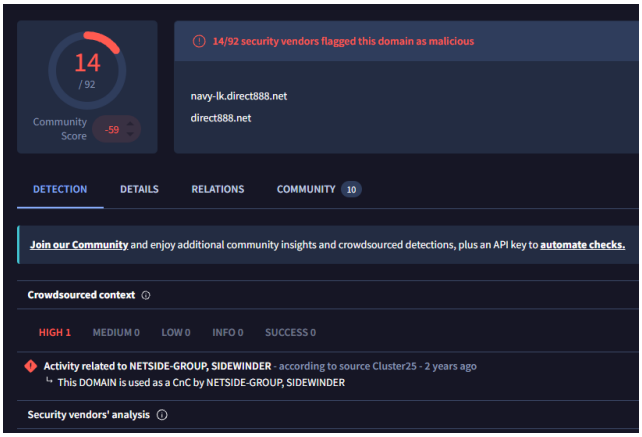
SHA256 Hash: 15ce7d3c879975ca81777cf58f47409283e34ec1fe8e966fde608bc7eda16646

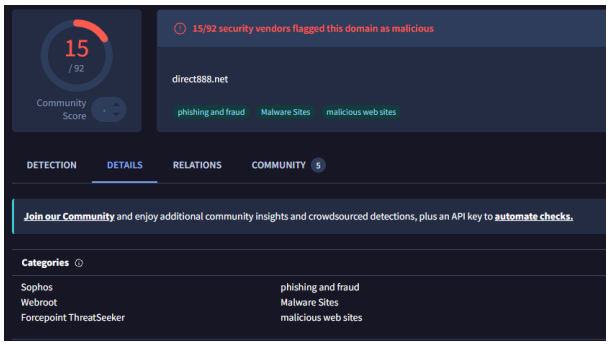
IOC Domains: direct888[.]net, navy-lk.direct888[.]net

Talos Intelligence flags the file hash as a Microsoft Word 2007+ trojan. VirusTotal has also flagged the hash as malicious, noting that it takes advantage of CVE-2017-0199 and that the file has contacted 2 suspicious domains: direct888[.]net and navy-lk.direct888[.]net. Both domains have been reported as being used in phishing attacks by SideWinder.









Possible Vulnerability Exploited: CVE-2017-0199

NIST reports that CVE-2017-0199 allows for attackers to remotely execute code when a document is opened using several older versions of Office: Microsoft Office 2007 SP3, Microsoft Office 2010 SP2, Microsoft Office 2013 SP1, Microsoft Office 2016, Microsoft Windows Vista SP2, Windows Server 2008 SP2, Windows 7 SP1, and Windows 8.1. Microsoft released a patch on April 11, 2017. The alert was triggered by C:\Program Files\Microsoft Office\Office16\WINWORD.EXE, the Microsoft Word process.

CVE-2017-0199 Detail

Description

Microsoft Office 2007 SP3, Microsoft Office 2010 SP2, Microsoft Office 2013 SP1, Microsoft Office 2016, Microsoft Windows Vista SP2, Windows Server 2008 SP2, Windows 7 SP1, Windows 8.1 allow remote attackers to execute arbitrary code via a crafted document, aka "Microsoft Office/WordPad Remote Code Execution Vulnerability w/Windows API."

Possible Threat Actor: SideWinder

Mitre ATT&CK identifies SideWinder with G0121, a threat group known for their phishing campaigns. The suspicious domains, IP address, and file behavior are all known to be affiliated with SideWinder.

Recommendations:

The compiled threat intelligence warrants escalation.

1. Investigate the activity on DESKTOP-AHG74N 10 minutes before and after 2024-01-05 14:04:23 UTC verify malware behavior and impact.
2. Obtain a copy of the email delivered to Bobby. The Subject line and Sender Address should be used verify if other users have received the same email or one similar with the malware attached.
3. Query the environment for the malicious file hash. Other devices may have downloaded the malware but may not have executed it yet.
4. Search for outbound traffic to 5[.]180[.]114[.]198, direct888[.]net, and navy-lk.direct888[.]net to verify the scope of affected devices.
5. Isolate the affected devices from the network and block all network communication with 5[.]180[.]114[.]198, direct888[.]net, and navy-lk.direct888[.]net.